

CPP SAT Reading & Writing Concept Reference

College Prep Program • Student Reference

A standard resource covering every tested SAT Reading & Writing skill: recognize the question type, apply a repeatable method, and review with Khan Academy.



Download this reference

Scan the code, or visit:

khalascholars.org/psat-rw

How to Use This Reference

- Identify the question type from the stem before solving.
- Use the listed method in the same order every time.
- Predict before reading choices whenever the skill allows it.
- After reviewing a mistake, open the linked Khan Academy lesson and complete targeted practice.
- Answer the self-check questions without looking back; retrieval strengthens memory.
- After each Bluebook test, look up every skill from your error log here, then complete the matching Khan Academy practice.

Quick-Reference Map

Use this page to identify the skill quickly. Turn to the full section for the method, traps, example, and self-check questions. The Khan Academy references under each section link directly to that skill's lesson article in the SAT Reading and Writing course — click the lesson name to open it.

Skill	Recognize it	First move
Central Ideas & Details	Main idea or supported detail	State the passage's main point in one sentence.
Inferences	Which choice logically completes the text?	Use only what the passage forces.
Textual Evidence	Which finding/quotation best supports a claim?	Define the exact claim first.
Quantitative Evidence	Graph or table supports a claim	Read axes, units, and categories first.
Words in Context	Most logical and precise word	Predict your own word before choices.
Structure & Purpose	Why written / how organized / sentence function	Use an active verb for what the author does.
Cross-Text Connections	Two texts; relationship or response	Summarize each stance separately.
Transitions	Logical connector between ideas	Name the relationship first.
Rhetorical Synthesis	Bulleted notes plus a stated goal	Read the goal before the notes.
Boundaries	Punctuation and clause joining	Check whether each side is a complete sentence.
Form, Structure & Sense	Verb, agreement, modifier, pronoun	Scan what changes across the choices.

INFORMATION AND IDEAS

Central Ideas and Details

Khan Academy: [Central Ideas and Details](#)

What this skill tests

Main-idea questions ask what the passage is primarily saying. Detail questions ask what the passage directly supports. Both must be answered from the text—not outside knowledge.

How to recognize it

Stems ask for the “main idea,” “central idea,” or a detail that is “supported by the text.”

Core strategy

Restate the passage in plain language before looking at the options.

Step-by-step method

1. Read the passage and identify its subject and main claim.
2. Write a one-sentence summary in your own words.
3. For a detail question, return to the exact supporting line.
4. Choose the answer that matches the whole passage or the cited detail.
5. Reject answers that add information the passage never states.

Common traps

- A true detail presented as the main idea.
- A choice broader than the passage.
- A plausible but unsupported statement.

Mini-example

A passage explains that urban trees reduce heat and improve air quality. “Urban trees provide several measurable environmental benefits” is a better main idea than “Trees are attractive.”

Check your understanding

1. How is a main idea different from a supporting detail?
2. Why can a factually true statement still be wrong?

Inferences

Khan Academy: [Inferences](#)

What this skill tests

Inference questions ask for the conclusion that most logically follows from the stated evidence. They are controlled logic questions, not invitations to speculate.

How to recognize it

The stem often asks which choice “most logically completes the text.”

Core strategy

Treat the passage as premises and select only the conclusion they support.

Step-by-step method

1. Identify the facts, comparisons, or results given.
2. Ask what must or most reasonably follows.
3. Predict a cautious conclusion.
4. Match the prediction to the choices.

5. Reject answers requiring an extra assumption.

Common traps

- Extreme language such as always, never, or proves.
- Outside knowledge.
- A conclusion that reverses the passage's timeline or comparison.

Mini-example

If plants receiving more light grew taller than otherwise identical plants, a supported inference is that increased light was associated with greater growth—not that light always guarantees growth.

Check your understanding

1. What makes an inference “controlled”?
2. Why are extreme words often suspicious?

Command of Evidence: Textual

Khan Academy: [Command of Evidence: Textual](#)

What this skill tests

The task is to select the quotation or research finding that most strongly supports a stated claim or hypothesis.

How to recognize it

The stem presents a claim and asks which choice would best support it.

Core strategy

Pin down every part of the claim before judging evidence.

Step-by-step method

1. Underline the claim's subject, direction, and scope.
2. Predict what supporting evidence would need to show.
3. Evaluate each option against the exact claim.
4. Prefer direct evidence over merely related information.
5. Confirm that the evidence strengthens rather than weakens the claim.

Common traps

- Evidence supporting a nearby but different claim.
- A result that is interesting but irrelevant.
- Evidence supporting the older view the passage challenges.

Mini-example

Claim: A bird changes its call in noisy settings. Strong evidence: recordings show the same birds consistently using higher-pitched calls when traffic noise increases.

Check your understanding

1. Why must every word of the claim matter?
2. What distinguishes related evidence from supporting evidence?

Command of Evidence: Quantitative

Khan Academy: [Command of Evidence: Quantitative](#)

What this skill tests

These questions combine a passage with a graph or table. The answer must be both numerically accurate and relevant to the argument.

How to recognize it

A chart, graph, or table appears beside a claim or sentence completion.

Core strategy

Read the visual first, then connect the correct data to the claim.

Step-by-step method

1. Read the title, axes, units, legend, and categories.
2. Identify the comparison required by the claim.
3. Estimate or calculate the relevant values.
4. Check each answer for numerical accuracy.
5. Then check whether it actually supports the passage's point.

Common traps

- A true statement that does not support the argument.
- A relevant statement that misreads the data.
- Ignoring units, scales, or category labels.

Mini-example

If a graph shows 62% for Group A and 41% for Group B, the evidence supports “Group A had a higher rate,” not “most members of both groups succeeded.”

Check your understanding

1. What two tests must the correct answer pass?
2. Why should you read the graph before the prose?

CRAFT AND STRUCTURE

Words in Context

Khan Academy: [Words in Context](#)

What this skill tests

Choose the most logical and precise word for a blank or determine a word's meaning as used in the passage. Context, tone, and logic control the answer.

How to recognize it

The stem asks which choice “most logically and precisely completes the text” or what a word “most nearly means.”

Core strategy

Predict a simple word or phrase before reading the options.

Step-by-step method

1. Read the full sentence and nearby context.
2. Find clues such as contrast, restatement, example, or tone.
3. Predict your own word.
4. Match each option to the prediction.
5. Reread with the survivor and check precision.

Common traps

- The most familiar dictionary meaning.
- A near-synonym with the wrong tone.
- A word related to the topic but opposite in logic.

Mini-example

If a researcher challenges a widely accepted assumption, “skeptical” may fit better than “curious” because the context shows doubt, not mere interest.

Check your understanding

1. Why predict before reading choices?
2. When two options “sort of” fit, what decides?

Text Structure and Purpose

Khan Academy: [Text Structure and Purpose](#) · [Part-to-Whole Relationships](#)

What this skill tests

Determine the text's main purpose, overall organization, or the role of one sentence within the whole passage.

How to recognize it

Stems ask what the author's “main purpose” is, how the text is “structured,” or what an underlined sentence “does.”

Core strategy

Describe function with an active verb: introduces, contrasts, explains, illustrates, qualifies, or concludes.

Step-by-step method

1. Identify whether the stem asks about the whole passage or one part.
2. Summarize the passage's movement in plain language.
3. State the purpose or function using an active verb.
4. Match the answer to the full text or the underlined sentence.
5. Reject choices describing content but not function.

Common traps

- A choice true of only one section.
- Confusing topic with purpose.
- Slightly altered language that changes the author's role.

Mini-example

A sentence giving an exception after a general claim likely “qualifies the preceding claim,” not merely “provides another example.”

Check your understanding

1. Why are active verbs useful for purpose questions?
2. How does part-to-whole differ from main purpose?

Cross-Text Connections

Khan Academy: [Cross-Text Connections](#)

What this skill tests

Two short texts address the same topic. The task is to identify how one author would respond to, support, challenge, or qualify the other.

How to recognize it

Two labeled texts appear, followed by a relationship or response question.

Core strategy

Lock down each author's position separately before comparing.

Step-by-step method

1. Summarize Text 1's claim.
2. Summarize Text 2's claim.
3. Name the relationship: support, counter, qualify, extend, or apply.
4. Check which author the stem asks about.
5. Choose the answer consistent with both texts.

Common traps

- Blending the two viewpoints.
- Claiming full agreement when overlap is partial.
- Answering from only one text.

Mini-example

Text 1 says a policy works broadly; Text 2 says it works only under certain conditions. Text 2 qualifies Text 1 rather than fully contradicting it.

Check your understanding

1. What must be established before comparing?
2. Name two relationships beyond agree/disagree.

EXPRESSION OF IDEAS

Transitions

Khan Academy: [Transitions](#)

What this skill tests

Choose the transition that accurately expresses the logical relationship between two ideas.

How to recognize it

A blank appears at the start of or within a sentence, with transition words as choices.

Core strategy

Name the relationship before evaluating specific words.

Step-by-step method

1. Read the sentence before and after the blank.
2. Classify the relationship: addition, contrast, cause, example, sequence, or conclusion.
3. Predict a transition category.
4. Eliminate options from the wrong categories.
5. Reread for logic and punctuation.

Common traps

- Choosing what merely sounds smooth.
- Confusing contrast with continuation.
- Ignoring the direction of cause and effect.

Mini-example

“The method is inexpensive. However, it requires considerable time.” The second sentence contrasts with the first.

Check your understanding

1. What should you determine before looking at transitions?
2. What relationship does “therefore” signal?

Rhetorical Synthesis

Khan Academy: [Rhetorical Synthesis](#)

What this skill tests

Use bulleted notes to produce a sentence that achieves a specific rhetorical goal. Accuracy alone is not enough; the answer must satisfy the goal.

How to recognize it

The question gives research notes and a stem such as “The student wants to emphasize...”

Core strategy

Read the goal first and use it as a filter.

Step-by-step method

1. Read the goal before the notes.
2. Identify the key verb: introduce, compare, contrast, emphasize, explain, or illustrate.
3. Scan only for facts relevant to that goal.
4. Predict what a successful sentence should focus on.
5. Reject true but off-goal choices.

Common traps

- Choosing a correct statement aimed at the wrong purpose.
- Including unnecessary facts that dilute the goal.
- Ignoring which person, work, or comparison the stem names.

Mini-example

If the goal is to emphasize a difference, an answer listing similarities is wrong even if every fact is accurate.

Check your understanding

1. What should be read before the notes?
2. Can a completely true choice still be wrong? Why?

STANDARD ENGLISH CONVENTIONS

Boundaries

Khan Academy: [Punctuation](#) · [Linking Clauses](#) · [Supplements](#)

What this skill tests

Determine how complete sentences, dependent clauses, and supplements should be joined or separated. These are rule questions; style preference is not tested.

How to recognize it

Choices differ mainly in periods, semicolons, commas, colons, dashes, or conjunctions.

Core strategy

Determine the grammatical status of each side before choosing punctuation.

Step-by-step method

1. Locate the blank and compare what changes across choices.
2. Decide whether each side is an independent clause.
3. Use a period or semicolon between two independent clauses, or comma + coordinating conjunction.
4. Use a colon only after a complete sentence.
5. Check that supplements use matching punctuation on both sides.

Common traps

- Comma splice between two complete sentences.
- Semicolon with a dependent clause.
- Comma between subject and verb.
- Mismatched punctuation around a supplement.

Mini-example

“The experiment ended; the researchers analyzed the results.” Both sides are complete, so the semicolon is legal. A comma alone would not be.

Check your understanding

1. What can legally join two independent clauses?
2. If a dash opens a supplement, what usually closes it?

Form, Structure, and Sense

Khan Academy: [Subject-Verb Agreement](#) · [Verb Forms](#) · [Subject-Modifier Placement](#)

What this skill tests

Choose the form that creates a grammatically complete and logically placed sentence. Common targets include subject-verb agreement, verb form, pronoun agreement, and modifier placement.

How to recognize it

Choices differ in verb number or tense, pronouns, participles, or the noun immediately following an opening phrase.

Core strategy

Scan the differences first; then apply the one rule being tested.

Step-by-step method

1. Identify exactly what changes across the options.
2. Find the true subject and ignore interrupting phrases.
3. Use time cues and parallel verbs to choose verb form.

4. Match pronouns to antecedents in number.
5. After an opening modifier, ensure the next noun is the thing being described.

Common traps

- Matching the verb to the nearest noun instead of the subject.
- Ignoring the passage's timeframe.
- Leaving two competing main verbs.
- A dangling modifier attached to the wrong noun.

Mini-example

“The collection of poems is...” is singular because collection is the subject. “Written in 1920, the novel...” correctly places novel after the modifier.

Check your understanding

1. Why should interrupters be crossed out mentally?
2. What noun must follow an opening modifying phrase?